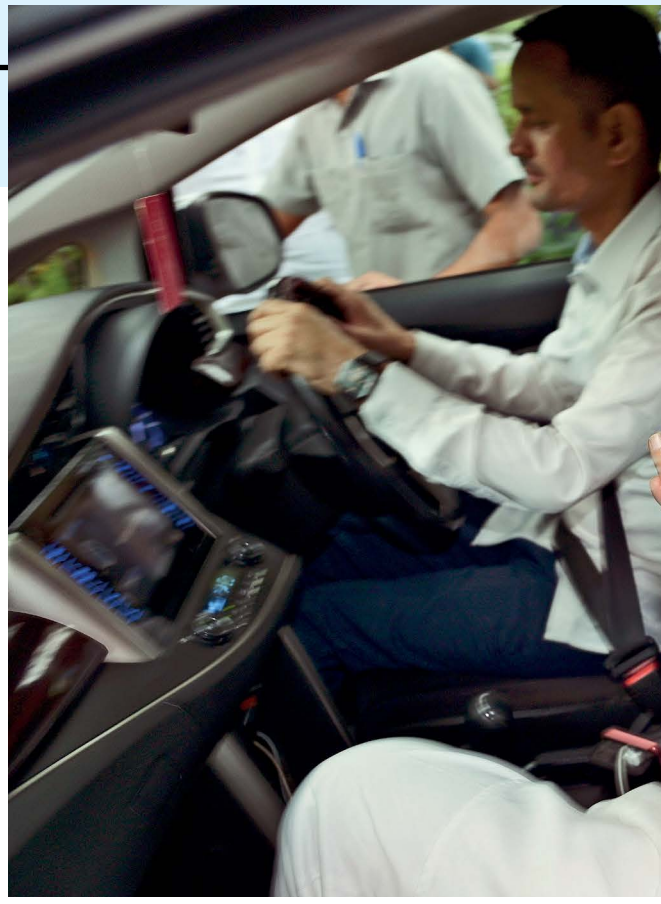


tenure in which DKS would get a shot at the top job, but that did not figure in the eventual announcement. The latter, however, will also keep the post of KPCC chief. The Congress was essentially playing it safe here. With a crucial Lok Sabha election in a year's time, and having coasted to power with a 43 per cent vote share, it is looking to ride the prevailing mood in Karnataka. But even ahead of the election, Siddaramaiah was seen to have the edge in a popularity contest—in fact, an early gambit to test the waters on that front had come in August 2022 when his supporters organised a mega rally at Davanagere in central Karnataka to celebrate his 75th birthday. Close aides say the success of that rally, which Rahul Gandhi had attended, had given Siddaramaiah the assurance he was looking for. In contrast, DKS's Achilles heel is that he faces several cases of income-tax evasion and money-laundering, which, he maintains, are a consequence of locking horns with the BJP in the past, especially in helping out the late Ahmed Patel win a crucial Rajya Sabha election in Gujarat in 2017.

Hailing from Siddaramanahundi village in Mysuru, Siddaramaiah, who goes by his first name, is a lawyer by training who was drawn to Lohiaite socialism and won his first election in 1983 from Chamundeshwari, contesting as an independent. For the next two decades, he was part of the Janata Parivar in its various avatars, twice serving as deputy chief minister. In 2005, his bid at social engineering as an Ahinda leader (the Kannada acronym for the grouping of minorities, backward classes and Dalits) led to a fallout with mentor and Janata Dal (Secular) chief H.D. Deve Gowda, following which he joined the Congress. A blunt-speaking politician, Siddaramaiah had led the party charge in the assembly in the past five years as leader of the Opposition. "Between 2013 and 2018, when we were in power, we fulfilled all our promises. People remember our programmes," he told INDIA TODAY in an interview in April, explaining that the priority ahead would be to address corruption. "People are talking about corruption on the street. This has never happened before in Karnataka." Siddaramaiah has also been a strident critic of the quantum of central funds allocated to Karnataka, calling it an injustice to the state. "Every year, they are reducing the central assistance. Thereby, a situation was created where the state government had to take on more debt," he says. "This year, the outgo on repaying debt is Rs 56,000 crore, according to the budget. If you reduce this, say, by Rs 20,000 crore or even Rs 15,000 crore...at least that much will be freed up for development."

The immediate challenge before the new government, however, will be the implementation of the five Congress guarantees, the main plank on which the party fought the election. It had promised to take these up—a mix of new schemes and extensions of existing ones—in the first cabinet meeting of the new government. For instance, while Karnataka already provides free power of up to 75 units to SC/ST families, the Congress has promised 200 units of free power to every household. Similarly, BPL families currently get 5 kg of free rice—this will go up to 10 kg of foodgrains. The other three guarantees are new schemes—monthly allowance of Rs 2,000 for every woman who heads a family, unemployment dole of Rs 3,000 for graduates and Rs 1,500 for diploma-holders for two years; and free bus travel for women in state transport buses.

Karnataka's annual expenditure on subsidies for the current fiscal is estimated at Rs 31,367 crore, or 13.8 per cent of total revenue receipts. Nearly 42 per cent of this—an estimated Rs 13,163 crore—goes to power subsidies, including supply of free electricity to irrigation pump sets. Foodgrains distribution, agriculture and housing subsidies make up the remainder. The Medium Term Fiscal Plan 2023-27 says the state's non-scheme committed expenditure will rise steeply year-on-year owing to higher outgo on salaries, pensions and interest payments. Expenditure on these heads is already 60 per cent of revenue receipts. "Hence, there is an urgent need for greater revenue mobilisation as well as rationalisation of subsidies to sustain the projected levels of committed expenditure within the limits of Karnataka Fiscal Responsibility Act, 2002," the